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Enterprise Software Is Shifting Toward Business-First ERP Design



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Discrete Development (Source: Discrete Development)

Enterprise software has never been more capable. Yet many organizations continue to struggle to realize the value they expected from their ERP investments. As ERP adoption continues to grow, a report estimates that more than 70% of recently implemented ERP initiatives will fail (<https://www.deloitte.com/us/en/insights/topics/technology-management/tech-trends/2025/tech-trends-impact-of-future-state-it-core-modernization.html>) to fully achieve their original business case by 2027.

Those figures suggest the challenge extends beyond technology itself and into how businesses approach implementation. Many organizations still rely on one-size-fits-all systems that require companies to conform to software rather than software adapting to the business.

Kevin Wagner, founder and systems architect at Discrete Development (<https://www.discrete-dev.com/>), believes that assumption has shaped enterprise technology for decades. Drawing on more than 20 years in broadcasting and over a decade of designing enterprise systems, he argues that digital transformation often begins with selecting software instead of understanding how a business actually operates. From his perspective, that sequence creates unnecessary complexity before implementation even begins.

“The business should define the technology,” Wagner says. “When software is designed around the way people already work, it becomes something they naturally use instead of something they have to learn how to fight.”

According to Wagner, traditional ERP implementations frequently begin with large, feature-rich templates intended to support virtually every scenario. While comprehensive, those platforms often introduce menus, workflows, and functions that many organizations never use. He explains that businesses spend significant time removing unnecessary complexity instead of building systems around the processes that matter most. In his experience, software should grow alongside an organization through modular capabilities rather than forcing companies to navigate functionality they may never need.

That philosophy extends to how Wagner defines sophistication. He believes the industry has become accustomed to equating complexity with capability, even though users experience software through everyday tasks rather than feature lists.

“Simplicity is sophistication,” Wagner says. “Every extra screen, workflow, or decision point introduces friction. Good technology should disappear into the background so people can focus on their work.”

His approach reflects a broader shift within enterprise technology. A successful ERP transformation depends on business-led strategy (<https://www.deloitte.com/us/en/services/consulting/articles/erp-strategy-and-implementation.html>) rather than technology alone, with organizations defining business capabilities before selecting digital solutions.

Wagner also believes many implementations overlook the people with the clearest understanding of operational reality. Leadership naturally defines business objectives, he explains, but employees using systems every day often understand where inefficiencies exist and where manual workarounds have quietly become part of daily operations. His process begins by listening to both perspectives, following workflows from the production floor through management before recommending technology.

He also favors validating ideas in real-world environments before expanding them. Rather than assuming a design will succeed because it works conceptually, Wagner believes testing solutions where processes are less predictable exposes weaknesses earlier and produces stronger systems over time. That perspective, shaped by years building mission-critical broadcasting systems where reliability was essential, continues to influence how he approaches enterprise software today.

Artificial intelligence represents another opportunity to rethink enterprise systems, although Wagner believes its role should remain collaborative. “AI can automate repetitive work extremely well,” he says. “People contribute judgment, creativity, and the ability to recognize better ways of working. The strongest systems combine both.”

As organizations continue investing in automation, Wagner expects successful ERP platforms to become increasingly modular, adaptable, and closely aligned with the businesses they support. Instead of asking companies to reshape established operations around predetermined software, he believes enterprise technology should evolve alongside changing business needs while preserving the strengths that made those organizations successful in the first place.

“The future of ERP will not be defined by how many features a platform offers,” Wagner says. “It will be defined by how naturally it supports the people using it every day. Businesses don’t need more software. They need software that understands how they work.”

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